

Persuasion, Strategy, and the Microdynamics of Right-Wing Mainstreaming in the U.S.

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Abstract

In the U.S., as in many countries in Western Europe and elsewhere, far-right political actors and movements have developed stronger relationships with the political mainstream over time. What explains a seemingly electorally counterproductive alliance between far-right provocateurs and institutional elites? We investigate the relationship between extremist media figures and Republican Party elites in the United States using time-stamped corpora of far-right podcast transcripts and congressional floor speeches, exploring *whether*, *how*, and *when* the rhetorical content of the far-right shapes elite discourse, or whether the reverse may be true. Through topic modeling and time-series analysis, we identify patterns of thematic convergence and directionality of influence across these two domains. We argue that far-right actors build relationships with the political mainstream by slowly and systematically developing a library of shared rhetoric and a framework of common language, a pattern in which the far right leads newer mainstream conservative politicians to adopt its messaging in areas related to core themes of right populism while more established mainstream conservatives use the far right as a service provider to amplify movement-building programs and messages in order to reach otherwise difficult-to-access populations, markets, and organizations.

On Alex Jones’s InfoWars network, the weekend of May 31st, 2024, was even more dramatic and eventful than it was on more mainstream news networks. Friday’s coverage focused to some extent on Donald Trump’s felony convictions in New York state court, with guests including cryptocurrency celebrity Mario Nawfal; journalist with ties to Fox News, NewsMax, and OAN, Nick Sortor; and overt white supremacist, Hitler enthusiast, Catholic authoritarian, and Donald Trump dinner companion Nick Fuentes. Each guest was encouraged to defend Trump in conspiratorial terms, and in each segment provocative language suggested that the U.S. currently lives under centrist, establishment authoritarian governance:

The Republican establishment stabbed Trump in the back. 100%. And so the January Six thing, and everything that happened since, including the censorship, including, you know, that dragnet everybody got caught up in, it was about disabling and paralyzing any kind of activism. And that is the thing that they don’t want people to do. They want people to, you know, watch the show, buy the shirt, back to the regularly scheduled programming. They do not want people to get involved. That’s why they called the school board parents terrorists. That’s why they arrested the January Sixers. And fundamentally, that is why they’re going after Trump.

The following day, Jones and his employees returned to the InfoWars studio for a pair of “emergency broadcasts”, in which they announced that the “globalist” conspiracy intended to seize control of the corporation and change the locks on the doors as part of ongoing bankruptcy proceedings in the wake of libel lawsuits regarding statements made by Jones and InfoWars about parents of victims killed at an elementary school mass shooting. On that subsequent broadcast, Jones was joined by extremist guests like the infamous QAnon shaman of January 6th fame, but also by high-profile Trump administration insiders such as Steve Bannon, General Michael Flynn, and Roger Stone.

Why are political insiders, with careers connected to powerful figures in the mainstream of a major U.S. party, willing to share a broadcast with figures from the insurgent right—neo-Nazis, QAnon promoters, and participants in the January 6th insurrection?

The episode illustrates a key puzzle: *How do fringe political movements migrate into the political mainstream, and what is the role of ideas in facilitating this?* In recent years, ideas and rhetoric once confined to the outermost edges of political discourse have increasingly appeared in the speeches of elected officials, the platforms of major parties, and the agendas of policymaking institutions in the United States and beyond. This raises questions not only about *directionality*—does influence flow primarily from the fringe to the mainstream or vice versa?—but also about the *mechanisms* by which such influence operates. Is there a direct pipeline, or do ideas, and the underlying relationships for which they serve as a proxy, diffuse through a more complex ecosystem of actors in the broader right-wing media and political sphere?

This paper investigates those questions by examining the relationship between extremist media figures and Republican Party elites in the United States. Using time-stamped corpora of far-right podcast transcripts and congressional floor speeches, we explore *whether* and *how* the rhetorical content of the far-right shapes elite discourse, or whether the reverse may be true. Through topic modeling and time-series analysis, we identify patterns of thematic convergence and directionality of influence across these two domains.

While this inquiry centers on the U.S., the dynamics it captures are far from unique. Across liberal democracies, observers have noted a growing convergence between radical right discourse and the rhetoric of mainstream political actors. Much of the existing literature has sought to explain the rise of the far-right by focusing either on individual-level political behavior—such as why voters support far-right parties—or on institutional dynamics like party competition, media incentives, or electoral systems. These explanations have generated important insights into the conditions under which far-right movements thrive.

However, they often leave underexplored the puzzling persistence and diffusion of more *extreme or fringe ideas* within mainstream right-wing discourse, that is ideas that are not merely electorally unpopular, but seemingly self-sabotaging in their extremity. If far-right success is to be explained in instrumental or strategic terms, what explains the recurring incorporation of content that appears to endanger that very success?

We argue that such a development can only be understood by shifting analytical attention to a more intermediate, or *meso-level*, perspective: the information and discourse environment in which right-wing actors operate. Rather than focusing solely on electoral behavior or formal institutions, we examine how actors within the right-wing ecosystem encounter, circulate, and potentially amplify ideas from the fringe—shaping the boundaries of what is politically thinkable, sayable, and eventually actionable. This process helps the far right build the relationships with the mainstream that are politically necessary for broader success; as such, tracking shared ideas can serve as a way of examining the development of cross-stream right-of-center elite political relationships. We suggest that mainstream conservatives use the far right strategically, initially cultivating a relationship in which they rarely adopt ideas and language from that milieu and instead use far-right platforms to amplify their own programs and right-leaning movement-building endeavors, focusing on topics that are initially low-salience for established constituencies so that they can purchase engagement and enthusiasm from far-right audiences at low short-term cost from mainstream conservative followers. As the mainstreaming and normalization processes play out, however, the set of topics on which mainstream conservative elites regard far-right voices as legitimate sources expands, and eventually mainstream conservatives turn to the far right as a legitimate source for frames and narratives on topics core to the growing domain of right-populist ideological issues.

This perspective also offers a novel lens on political polarization. Polarization in the United States is typically understood in terms of partisan alignment, affective hostility, or ideological divergence. But one crucial dimension is the *radicalization* of political actors, especially when one party shifts not only away from the center but toward positions once considered far outside the bounds of liberal democratic consensus. In this sense, the increasing mainstreaming of fringe content within the GOP may not only be a consequence of polarization, but also a driver of it.

In what follows, we examine this process empirically. Our goal is twofold: first, to test whether and in which direction rhetorical influence flows between far-right media and institutional Republican actors; and second, to contribute a theoretical account of how and why such flows occur. In doing so, we aim to clarify the mechanisms by which fringe actors build relationships with institutional power—and to highlight the importance of the information ecosystem in understanding contemporary democratic backsliding.

Polarization and Extremism

Virtually all major developments in 21st-century American politics have unfolded within the broader context of increasing partisan polarization. The dynamics of right-wing political discourse and coalition-building are no exception. As such, polarization is a crucial theoretical category for understanding not only the structure of partisan competition but also the ideological evolution of the mainstream American right.

Political polarization, broadly defined, refers to the growing ideological distance and affective hostility between partisans, often accompanied by increased alignment between party identity and social, cultural, and demographic cleavages. Two classic scholars in this area, Fiorina and Abrams, identify the ideological aspect of polarization: “most scholars hold an intuitive notion of polarization as a bimodal distribution of observations” (Fiorina and Abrams 2008) in an opinion dimension. The other dimension of hostility reflects a now well-established but nonetheless more recent line of research: “Democrats and Republicans both say that the other party’s members are hypocritical, selfish, and closed-minded, and they are unwilling to socialize across party lines, or even to partner with opponents in a variety of other activities. This phenomenon of animosity between the parties is known as affective polarization” (Iyengar, Lelkes, Levendusky, Malhotra, and Westwood 2019).

The causes and consequences of polarization have been extensively studied in political science. Research has examined institutional drivers including primary elections, rules about money in politics, and congressional rules (Barber and McCarty 2015), as well as broader societal factors such as media fragmentation, Internet use and social media, changes in elite messaging, economic inequality, dynamics of mass negative stereotyping, and identity-based sorting as mechanisms that contribute to partisan division (Druckman and Levy 2022).

For our purposes, what matters most is the link between polarization and the ideological positioning of the mainstream right. Research suggests that polarization is not merely symmetrical drift but has been significantly driven by a rightward ideological shift within the Republican Party (McCarty 2015; Hacker and Pierson 2015; Broockman and Skovron 2018).

This literature has shown how ideological extremity and partisan identity reinforce one another, producing increasingly stark policy platforms and rhetorical styles. In the case of the Republican Party, polarization has coincided with a rightward ideological shift which has brought once-marginal ideas and rhetoric into the party’s mainstream.

The direction of this relationship, however, remains theoretically and empirically contested. On one hand, ideological radicalization might alienate moderate voters, posing risks to electoral competitiveness. On the other, high levels of partisan polarization may blunt those risks by insulating parties from electoral backlash, hardening partisan loyalty and reducing the costs of extremity. In this way, polarization may not only coexist with radicalization but actively enable it.

A key mechanism linking polarization to radicalization is the structure of primary elections. Because primary electorates tend to be more ideologically extreme than general electorates, legislators face strong incentives to position themselves closer to their base than to the median voter in their district (Brady, Han, and Pope 2007; Hall 2015). These incentives are further compounded by systematic misperceptions of constituents’ views. Republican legislators dramatically overestimate the conservatism of their districts, by as much as 20 percentage points, partly because ideologically motivated voters contact their representatives at disproportionately high rates (Broockman and Skovron 2018). The result is a structural bias toward adopting more extreme positions, independent of any direct exposure to far-right media.

Our research adds evidence that right-wing media actors feed legislators and their staffs a steady diet of extremist messages tailored to energize and activate exactly those most extreme constituents. This offers a way of understanding polarization as a product not just of communication between constituents and legislative offices but also as a strategic interaction between mainstream conservatives and extremists at the elite and mass level.

Mainstreaming and Extremism in Liberal Democracies

While polarization plays a particularly central role in the evolution of right-wing politics in the United States, driven by its two-party system and unusually high levels of partisan division, this does not make the broader

phenomenon of far-right mainstreaming uniquely American. In fact, several key features of the U.S. case parallel developments across a wide range of liberal democracies, particularly in Europe.

Multiparty systems have seen the rise of challenger parties on the radical right which have achieved mainstream status by securing electoral success, resulting in coalition bargaining power as well as formal government or opposition leadership. Rather than an established party adopting formerly non-mainstream ideologies as in the U.S., European far-right movements have more often built institutional legitimacy primarily through challenges at the ballot box. This has prompted a large body of scholarship seeking to explain when and why the far right succeeds. The literature is typically organized around demand- and supply-side explanations; it is the supply side that bears most directly on our argument, though demand-side accounts provide important context.

On the demand side, scholars have identified several forces that increase receptivity to far-right appeals: adverse labor market shocks linked to globalization (Colantone & Stanig, 2018; Autor et al., 2020; Rodrik, 2021; Dippel et al., 2022; Choi et al., 2024), anti-immigration attitudes that consistently outweigh economic variables as predictors of far-right support (Ivarsflaten, 2008; Mudde, 2016; Mudde, 2019; Valentino et al., 2019), and a cultural backlash among socially conservative voters against rapid value change (Norris & Inglehart, 2019). These factors illuminate why electorates become receptive to far-right appeals. They say less, however, about which specific ideas and narratives gain traction once that receptivity exists — the question at the center of our analysis.

That question points toward the supply side. One of the most influential findings in this tradition is that parties or candidates can actively shape the political agenda to their advantage by determining the salience and framing of issues they “own” (De Vries & Edwards, 2009; Druckman et al., 2013; Dennison, 2020; Hutter & Kriesi, 2022). By foregrounding issues like immigration, national identity, or crime, the far-right can shift public debate onto terrain where they enjoy a perceived advantage, even if the underlying public opinion on those issues is not uniformly favorable to their positions.

This process is often facilitated by other actors. First, centrist parties may contribute to the far-right’s mainstreaming by accommodating it, i.e. adopting its issues, rhetoric, or policy positions in an attempt to capture its voters (Dahlström & Sundell, 2012; Spoon & Klüver, 2020; Krause et al., 2023; Valentim et al., 2023). Such convergence can lend legitimacy to previously marginal positions and further elevate their salience. Second, the media can amplify far-right issue ownership by disproportionately covering or framing political debate around the topics the far right prioritizes (DellaVigna & Kaplan, 2007; Boomgaarden & Vliegenthart, 2007; Hemmer, 2016; Haynes et al., 2016; Grossman et al., 2022; Völker & Saldivia Gonzatti, 2024).

More recently, scholars have emphasized the role of shifting social norms in enabling these dynamics. The electoral and rhetorical gains of the far right have been facilitated by an erosion of the informal norms that once rendered it “taboo” (Valentim, 2024). As these constraints weaken, far-right actors find it easier to enter coalition negotiations, dominate news cycles, and exert lasting influence on public discourse and institutional politics.

While these accounts help explain how the far right achieves electoral relevance and institutional footholds, they say less about the kinds of ideas and narratives that take hold once these parties enter the mainstream, particularly the persistence of rhetoric drawn from the outermost fringes of the political spectrum. Perhaps the most prominent and illustrative example of such extremist rhetoric entering mainstream political discourse is the so-called ***Great Replacement*** theory. Coined by French writer Renaud Camus in 2011, this conspiracy claims that a left-wing, globalist elite is systematically orchestrating the replacement of native European populations with non-white immigrants. Originally confined to fringe identitarian circles, the concept has since migrated into mainstream far-right party platforms across Europe, as party leaders now in positions of power or political relevance have publicly endorsed or echoed its themes, including prominent figures like Marine Le Pen, Viktor Orbán, and Matteo Salvini.

Existing scholarship often treats far-right positions as fixed, deriving directly from an underlying ideology, or explains them as products of party competition (Meguid, 2005; De Lange, 2007; Meguid, 2008; De Vries & Hobolt, 2020) and they indeed shift toward more popular positions when necessary Halikiopoulou et al.,

2013; Ivaldi, 2015; Enggist & Pinggera, 2022). Yet we lack a systematic understanding of how specific topics, narratives, and frames originate, and of how and when they enter institutional politics. This specificity matters because these concrete iterations of far-right ideology are the vehicles through which actors mobilize supporters, persuade the undecided, and shape public discourse.

Take for example the claim circulated in online neo-Nazi spaces in September 2024, alleging that Haitian immigrants in Ohio were eating their neighbors’ pet cats (Yousef 2024). Within weeks, the allegation was repeated by then-vice presidential candidate J.D. Vance and his running mate, Donald Trump, on the campaign trail. In this case, hostility toward immigrants was already an established position of the Republican ticket; what was novel was the adoption of a highly specific, inflammatory, and false narrative originating in extremist online subcultures, illustrating how ideas first articulated in fringe spaces are adapted in mainstream electoral politics.

We argue that this diffusion of extreme discourse is shaped by a shared media ecosystem, often transnational in character, where ideas circulate through podcasts, encrypted messaging platforms, video content, and alternative media channels. These channels allow extremist discourse to flourish outside formal political institutions, yet exert influence on institutional politics through individual actors within it, shaping the agenda and language of the far-right.

Communication Flows, Influence, and the Microdynamics of Extremist Mainstreaming

As we have seen, existing literature on the mainstreaming of far-right politics often focuses on macro-level outcomes, explaining the movement of candidates and parties from exclusion to positions of acceptance, electoral success, or political power. But as the far-right seeks to initially interact with mainstream conservatives from a position of disadvantage, the process involves persuasion, influence, communication, and many of the general microdynamics of outsider social movements in general (Downing, Ford, Gil, and Stein 2000). As the far-right becomes a more established player and an ally of establishment conservatives, communication will become more routinized, reciprocal, and public, as what were once two sides of a complex negotiation become instead coalition partners in political campaigns and governance.

The idea that non-electoral actors shape the ideological content of political parties has precedent in political science. Noel (2013) argues that ideological entrepreneurs, including columnists, writers, and intellectuals, created and transmitted ideological packages to parties, with measurable lags of roughly two decades between when ideas appeared in elite publications and when they showed up in congressional voting. Far-right podcasters play a structurally analogous role: they generate content outside formal political institutions that, as our data show, subsequently appears in elite political speech. The parallel, however, runs only so far. Noel’s intellectuals wrote for educated audiences in a slow-moving print ecosystem, and the ideological packages they developed were coherent, durable constructions with explicit philosophical underpinnings. The content that flows through the contemporary far-right media ecosystem is different in kind. It consists of specific narratives, conspiracy theories, and emotionally charged framings rather than systematic ideology, and the lags we document are measured in weeks rather than decades. The flows are also not one-directional: our results show patterns of amplification and two-way dialogue that suggest a more networked relationship than the intellectual-to-party pipeline Noel describes. What we are studying, then, is not the long-run construction of ideological coalitions but the short-run tactical diffusion of specific frames through a media ecosystem that did not exist when Noel wrote.

We hypothesize that this process of far-right mainstreaming involves an over-time change in the way that ideas flow between actors in far-right social movements and media spaces “on the outside” and mainstream conservatives “on the inside.” Before this process begins, mainstream conservatives likely engage with far-right ideas, language, and issue framing mostly in order to distance themselves from it.¹ When mainstream conservatives and the far-right are talking about issues in disconnected ways, we characterize this as a

¹As Walsh (2020) narrates in analyzing the history of the relationship between the far right and conservatives through the 20th century, this idea of the far right and mainstream conservatives as distant was not a permanent fact throughout all of history. Prior to about 1955, the two movements had a close working relationship, but the distancing described in the text developed in part as a way of managing the poor public image of far-right movements like the John Birch Society and related anti-Semitic and conspiratorial actors.

situation of **independent** streams of discourse.

As a project of mainstreaming begins, far-right actors will seek to develop ways of discussing issues that potentially appeal to the mainstream. This can sometimes involve introducing new ways of discussing established issues, but it is often easier and more productive for far-right media voices and movement leaders to entrepreneurially develop new issues for which mainstream conservatives lack — or have suppressed — existing frameworks (Kallis 2013: 227-33). By focusing on borrowing from far-right voices in novel domains, mainstream conservatives can appeal to the moderately-sized but active and potentially highly enthusiastic far-right electorate and activist pool, as well as to the group of conservative citizens who are curious about and open to more extreme messaging, without alienating established constituencies by disrupting the ideological appeals and messages which form the basis of their attachment. Over time, new far-right messages become familiar to established audiences, and mainstream elites can spread such messages across more of the party’s communication to energize the party base as the boundaries between mainstream conservatism and the far right become ambiguous. This mainstreaming communication strategy may be direct, in which conservative politicians or their staff members are directly exposed to, and proceed to make use of, language and ideas used by far-right media figures.

Alternatively, an indirect communication pathway may sometimes have strategic advantages in terms of obfuscating connections: far-right media voices may influence the way that mainstream conservative media figures discuss issues and ideas, and mainstream conservative politicians or their staff may take cues from mainstream conservative media even when the messages there are borrowed from more extreme sources. We refer to these communication pathways as **direct** or **indirect** mainstreaming, in which ideas and language from the far-right makes its way into mainstream discourse.

Messaging flowing in the opposite direction can represent a communications service provided by the far right to conservatives. If conservative messaging on an issue is subsequently picked up and repeated in far-right media and social-movement spaces, it can access to audiences and be heard with an emotional intensity that may be unreachable for mainstream conservatives. Thus, when mainstream, electoral conservatives’ ideas, framing, and language influences that of the non-electoral far-right, we refer to that as (direct or indirect) **amplification**. During the process of mainstreaming, amplification is a useful strategy for the far-right to prove its political worth to mainstream conservatives and to thereby bargain for further inclusion.

As the far right becomes more accepted by mainstream electoral conservatives, we expect these one-sided communications profiles to be replaced by two-sided conversations, in which far-right media figures attend and respond to politicians’ words and ideas, but politicians and their staffs likewise listen attentively to innovations in framing generated by the far-right media. This reciprocal flow among established political allies we characterize as two-way dialogue. Thus, tracking change in the flow of ideas becomes, we hypothesize, a powerful tool for studying the development of relationships between the far right and the conservative mainstream.

The actors on each side of these communication flows pursue quite different goals. Far-right media figures operate in an attention economy. Their incentives are to grow audience share, establish brand identity, and demonstrate political relevance to mainstream partners. Elected officials face a more complex calculus. Adopting far-right framing carries real electoral risk in general elections (Hall 2015), yet tends to be advantageous in primaries, where more extreme candidates fare better (Brady, Han, and Pope 2007). Recent work also shows that divisive rhetoric generates electoral rewards among base voters independent of policy achievement (Park 2023). Republican legislators further tend to overestimate the conservatism of their constituents by a substantial margin, partly because ideologically motivated voters contact their offices at higher rates (Broockman and Skovron 2018). The perceived electoral cost of adopting far-right frames is therefore lower than a straightforward reading of general election returns would suggest, and this creates structural demand for the rhetorical supply that far-right media provides.

Methods and Data

Because the hypotheses of interest involve the direction and intensity of influence over time among various corpora of conservative- and far-right political speech, the objective is to identify features of the texts that can be analyzed in a vector autoregression (VAR; see Freeman, Williams, and Lin 1989). In pursuit of that

goal, we proceed by collecting two main textual sources—far-right podcast transcripts and speeches from the U.S. House of Representatives—and modeling their topical content over time.

Corpus Collection and Topic Modeling With BERTopic

For the podcast corpus, we extract full transcripts from far-right and conspiratorial media outlets. We use the WhisperAI transcription model (Radford et al., 2023) to produce text transcripts of podcasts produced by Alex Jones’s InfoWars network, the Proud Boys, and Ben Shapiro. For the congressional corpus, we use transcripts of members’ speeches. We apply BERTopic separately to each corpus, identifying a set of latent topics and assigning probabilistic topic distributions to every time-stamped document. BERTopic combines a transformer-based document embedding model (here, SBERT: all-mpnet-base-v2) with UMAP-based dimensionality reduction, HDBSCAN clustering, and class-based TF-IDF (c-TF-IDF) to generate interpretable topic representations. For each document, we obtain a vector of topic probabilities indicating the relative prominence of each theme.

To enable meaningful cross-corpus comparison, we adopt a strategy in which the topic model is fit on one corpus and then applied to the other. Our primary analysis fits the topic model to the podcast corpus, allowing us to define topics rooted in far-right discourse. We then transform the GOP speech corpus using this model, yielding topic probabilities that reflect the salience of podcast-derived themes within elite congressional speech. This ensures that both corpora are represented in a shared topic space, making their thematic content directly comparable over time. As a robustness check, we also conduct the reverse procedure, that is we fit the topic model on GOP speeches and transform the podcast corpus to confirm that our findings are not artifacts of the initial topic definition.

A related concern with text corpora is that estimating a latent representation from the same data used for inference can introduce identification problems or overfitting (Egami et al. 2022). Our design limits these risks in three ways. First, the cross-corpus strategy embeds the logic of a split-sample workflow. The topic model is fit on the podcast corpus and applied, unchanged, to the congressional corpus, so the measure on the congressional side cannot be overfit to that corpus or to the cross-corpus relationships that carry our argument. Second, topic discovery is blind to the estimand because BERTopic clusters documents on semantic content without access to timestamps, leaving no channel through which the temporal ordering we study could shape topic definitions, and topic labels were assigned before the time-series analysis. Third, the reverse procedure we just described functions as a sample swap, confirming that the results do not depend on which corpus defines the topics.

After fitting and transforming, we aggregate topic probabilities at the weekly level for each corpus. This results in two parallel multivariate time series that track the salience of a common set of topics in far-right podcasts and congressional speech, respectively.

A critical feature of our approach is the use of a transformer-based sentence embedding model, specifically all-mpnet-base-v2, part of the Sentence-BERT (SBERT) family. Unlike the original BERT, which was designed primarily for token-level prediction tasks, SBERT adapts the architecture to produce high-quality, fixed-length sentence embeddings that preserve semantic relationships between texts. all-mpnet-base-v2 builds on MPNet (Song et al., 2020), which improves upon BERT and RoBERTa by capturing richer contextual dependencies through permuted language modeling and a more efficient attention mechanism. These embeddings serve as the foundation for BERTopic, enabling it to cluster documents based on nuanced thematic content rather than surface-level lexical overlap. This is especially important in our setting, where political language is often figurative, strategic, and highly contextual. Recent applications such as the GBERT fine-tuning for populism detection by (Erhard et al., 2025), highlight the advantages of these methods even in relatively low-resource settings. Leveraging SBERT embeddings and BERTopic’s structure-preserving clustering, we enhance both the thematic precision and temporal resolution of our analysis across two corpora that differ markedly in tone, formality, and discursive register. Our approach produces two multivariate time series, one for the podcast corpus and one for GOP congressional speech, in which each variable represents the weekly average salience of a given topic. The dimensions of each time series correspond to a shared set of topics, defined in the fitted BERTopic model. This structure allows us to observe how the prominence of specific themes rises and falls over time within and across corpora.

Time Series and Vector Autoregression

Once appropriate themes have been identified within each corpus, the focus turns to whether there are relationships of influence between the different actors behind the collections of texts in terms of when and how they use each theme. As an approach to this question, we consider whether there is a time ordering in the use of words that constitute each theme. If one actor’s use of the collection of words that make up a particular theme can predict another actor’s use of those same words in time, then we will interpret that as provisional evidence of influence from the first actor to the second with respect to this particular theme.

We regard the evidence as provisional because it is always possible that some third source is influencing both actors in our study, and that the observed time ordering is a result of that third source influencing one actor earlier or more strongly than the other. Our approach attempts to mitigate this possibility by using topics that are as specific as possible, increasing the likelihood of influence by the specific actors under analysis, and by employing relatively fine-grained time periods to reduce the scope for confounding. Nonetheless, it will be important to bear in mind that the results cannot be the final word in proving a relationship of influence (see discussion in Shojaie and Fox 2022).

Our approach is to analyze the collection of time series for each theme as a set. We look at the relationships across the various time series, asking for each about the predictive value of the past history of the entire set of time series for that theme. Our methodological approach here is vector autoregression, which involves regressing each time series on its past history as well as the past histories of all the other time series (up to a fixed number of lags). Then, we explore the impulse-response function (IRF), which shows the long-term dynamic within the model when there is a one-time shock to one time-series. If the various time series are all stationary and otherwise meet the standard conditions for time-series analysis, the IRF can help show whether or not there is the kind of predictive relationship we are treating as evidence of influence: if the IRF is not meaningfully different from zero, then there is no evidence of influence, whereas a significant positive IRF is evidence in support of some amount of influence.

To ensure comparability in time frames across data sources, we aggregate time-series data about the prevalence of each theme to the weekly level. A single fixed lag order does not serve every theme well: standard lag-length information criteria disagree sharply across themes, and diagnostic checks (reported in full in the Appendix) show that a long, uniform lag order leaves detectable residual autocorrelation and unstable estimated dynamics for the large majority of themes, chiefly because the number of weeks over which all three text collections simultaneously overlap is modest relative to the number of parameters such a specification requires. We therefore select a lag order separately for each theme: for every theme, we fit the VAR at every integer lag order from 1 to 20 and choose the smallest order at which the residuals pass a standard whiteness test and the estimated system is stable (non-explosive); where no lag in this range satisfies both criteria, we fall back to the most stable candidate with the least residual autocorrelation and flag this explicitly. The Appendix reports the full, theme-by-theme record of selected lag orders and the diagnostics underlying each choice. All models include linear time trends. In calculating IRFs, we project forward 20 weeks from an intervention, carrying out significance tests for each difference. Because of the large number of significance tests involved, it would not be surprising to have one significant result by chance. Hence, when classifying patterns by theme below, we typically pay attention only to themes that have two or more significant results. A more conservative alternative, restricting the underlying test to a 12-week Granger-causality window with correction for multiple comparisons, is presented in the Appendix.

Results

In order to first give a clear sense of the models and substantive patterns at work in these data, we begin with mixed-method case studies of three themes, selected both for substantive interest and to demonstrate the range of patterns apparent in the data as a whole. We will look closely at the time-series models and substantive politics behind conversations about election fraud and election denial, about discourse regarding genetically-modified organisms in agriculture and agribusiness conspiracies, and about the movement to designate Antifa as a domestic terrorist organization. These three topics remain major themes in the U.S. and global conservative populist and far-right to date, and they also illustrate three divergent patterns of persuasive dynamics, each of which allow far-right actors to play a different role in conservative politics.

Let us begin with election denial and claims of fraud (Arceneaux and Truex 2023). This issue area has

become a major focus of American politics over the last decade, with commissions established to search for voter fraud after the 2016 election, allegations of theft leading to lawsuits and an insurrection in 2020, and arguments about future fraud serving as the basis for a renewed push to eliminate voting by mail and other efforts to increase turnout during Trump’s second presidential term. Which actors were responsible for propagating these ideas?

It is well known that Donald Trump himself was a major source of the narrative that U.S. elections are fraudulent and unreliable (Axelrod 2022). He advanced this idea occasionally during the 2016 Republican primaries, objecting to caucus elections in which he performed less well than in primaries. He also made similar remarks about Democratic primary election outcomes that did not favor Bernie Sanders. During the final weeks of the 2016 general election, he also described the election as untrustworthy and refused to commit himself to respect the outcome unless he won, claiming that citizens were going to “come in and vote five times.” After the election, he claimed that he would have won the popular vote if not for the millions of illegal voters that he hypothesized. He made scattered comments of a similar nature relating to the 2018 midterm elections, once again alleging that many individuals were voting illegally. He reintroduced the idea of fraudulent elections in October of 2020 as his reelection campaign appeared troubled.

While Trump has returned to this topic repeatedly throughout his political life, the 2020 version of his election-fraud narrative was different (Craig and Gainous 2024). In the first place, previous iterations of the voter fraud narrative had focused on the claim that individuals had illegally voted (either citizens voting repeatedly under fake identities or noncitizens voting); in 2020, Trump instead offered theories that centered on elite and institutional fraud. Mail-in ballots were considered potentially fraudulent, as were electronic voting machines in heavily Democratic areas. Allegations were made that the vote-counting process itself had been subverted. While these shifts are a change of frames within the broad topic of election fraud, they also mark a clear departure between Trump’s pre-2020 approach and his discourse from October 2020 forward.

Second, Trump’s election-fraud claims in 2020 were widely amplified by elites and media actors, led to massive social movement activity, and ultimately have been politically consequential in a way that none of his other iterations of this idea ever were. What was different compared to past cycles? Obviously, one may point to the outcome, although Trump’s party also lost important ground in 2018 as well.

Our data show that, for this especially consequential round of election denial, Trump’s attacks were not in fact taking the rhetorical lead to the same extent as in the past. Instead, election denial discourse had already been taken over by other actors and seeded in conservative conversations for him. Our data show fifteen weeks between 2016 and the 2020 election in which election fraud and election denial topics made up at least one percent of the content of our far-right media corpus. Furthermore, these far-right messages had already begun the shift from voter-centric to elite- and institution-centric messaging. This alternative discourse had spread far enough and become entrenched enough that, for example, an audience member on InfoWars’s flagship program called in on March 11, 2019, to express his concerns about elite election manipulation: “I’m kind of at a loss and I need your help. I usually try to motivate a lot of people to vote when it comes time for the election and in 2018, the way the Democrats just stuffed all the ballots and brought in truckloads of ballots, a lot of my friends that I talk to, they’re not even motivated to vote in 2020 anymore because they feel like it’s hopeless. How do I really motivate people to get excited about voting in 2020 when they just feel like it’s useless because the Democrats are going to...” This is clearly the kind of message that would predominate in 2020, rather than the frame that had been prevalent in 2016 and 2018; the far-right messaging here was ahead of the game.

There are also three weeks each during the time period between 2016 and the 2020 election in which election-denial topics make up at least one percent of the content of our congressional and mainstream conservative text collections. Clearly, before Trump raised this theme in 2020, other actors had done the work to make election fraud resonate with conservative elites and audiences. Given the historical and political salience of these messages in particular during and after 2020, it is worth zooming in a bit on the relative time-ordering of these various actors’ messaging.

In particular, we want to ask, were far-right messages on election denial influential or irrelevant to the massive surge of discourse that arose late in 2020 and early in 2021? We can explore this with vector autoregression by

using the time series for far-right podcasts, conservative podcasts, and Republican Congressional speeches to predict each other. The results show a positive and statistically significant relationship from far-right discussions of electoral fraud to Congressional speeches on the same topic, after a lead time of one to two months. As seen in Figure 1, there are three separate time intervals where a shock to right-wing podcast discourse statistically significantly predicts an increase in election-denial discourse among Congressional Republicans, and there is an overall positive trend that falls short of significance which lasts for more than a month. There is, however, no evidence that mainstream conservative discourse follows far-right messaging at all, and at the margins it may even move in the opposite direction.

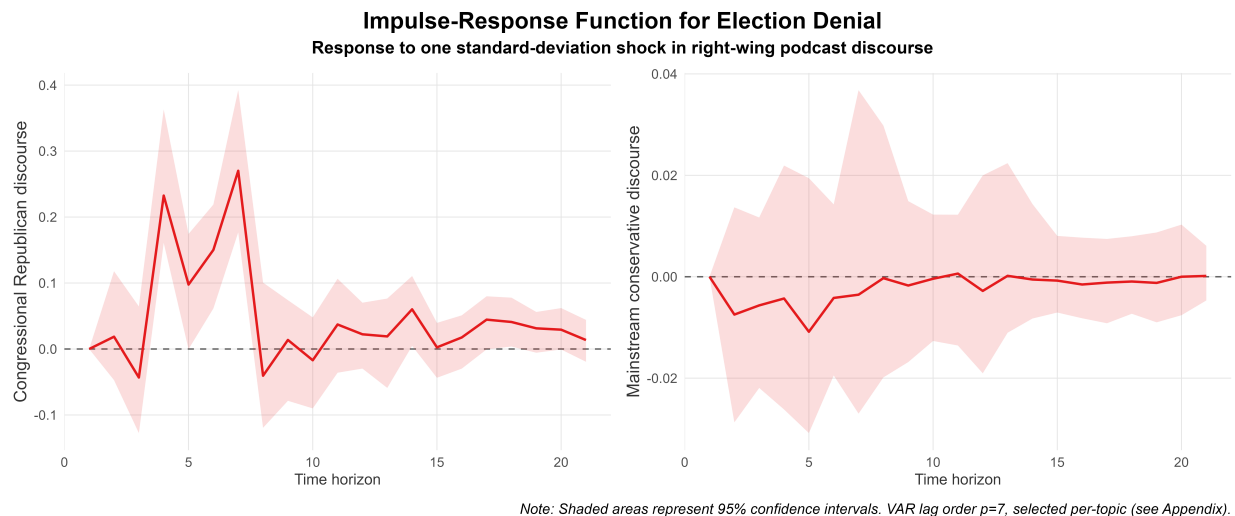


Figure 1: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to right-wing podcast discourse about election denial.

Congressional Republican discourse about election denial is not equally influential on far-right conversations, as seen in Figure 2. There is one statistically significant positive spike which stands as a deviation in a trend that is otherwise statistically insignificant and close to zero. Whether this means that far-right voices follow the lead of Congress on this theme after a respectful waiting period of two months, or alternatively that the one significant spike is a coincidence, is difficult to work out. However, the overall picture is clearly one in which Congress is not very influential overall on far-right discourse, whereas as seen previously far-right conversations show repeated and persistent evidence of influence on Congressional ways of talking about this issue. This asymmetry suggests a dynamic in which Congressional Republicans are reacting to far-right frames, rather than a two-way dialogue, especially given the timing in which far-right voices started talking about this topic in the 2020 cycle before other prominent actors.

Figure 2 also shows that mainstream conservatives were not detectably affected by Republican Congressional discussion on the topic of election fraud and election denial: the impulse-response function stays close to zero and statistically insignificant across the full 20-week horizon. Overall, the data suggest that Congressional Republicans were followers, not innovators, with respect to election denial, and that whatever influence exists on mainstream conservative media flows from elsewhere.

Likewise, as seen in Figure 3, there is no statistically significant connection in either direction between mainstream conservative discourse about election fraud and election denial and far-right discussion on this topic: both impulse-response functions remain close to zero and insignificant across the full horizon.

Taken as a whole, these results together with the information from above about timing present a picture in which far-right voices started the 2020 political cycle spreading discourse about the ultimately highly consequential theme of election fraud and election denial before mainstream conservatives or Congressional Republicans — and even before Donald Trump. Furthermore, statistical analysis of timing provides compelling evidence to suggest that Republicans in Congress were influenced in when and how they spoke on this issue by the far right, far more than the opposite. On this topic, we see an example of a dynamic in which the far right appears to influence conservative electoral politics but there is little or no evidence of an influence

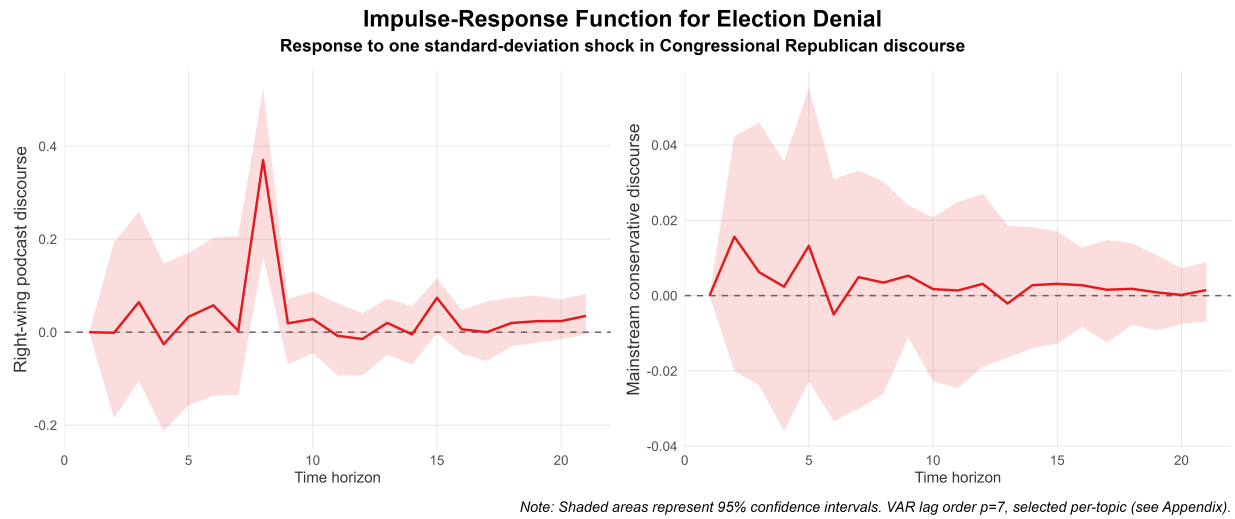


Figure 2: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to Congressional Republican discourse about election denial.

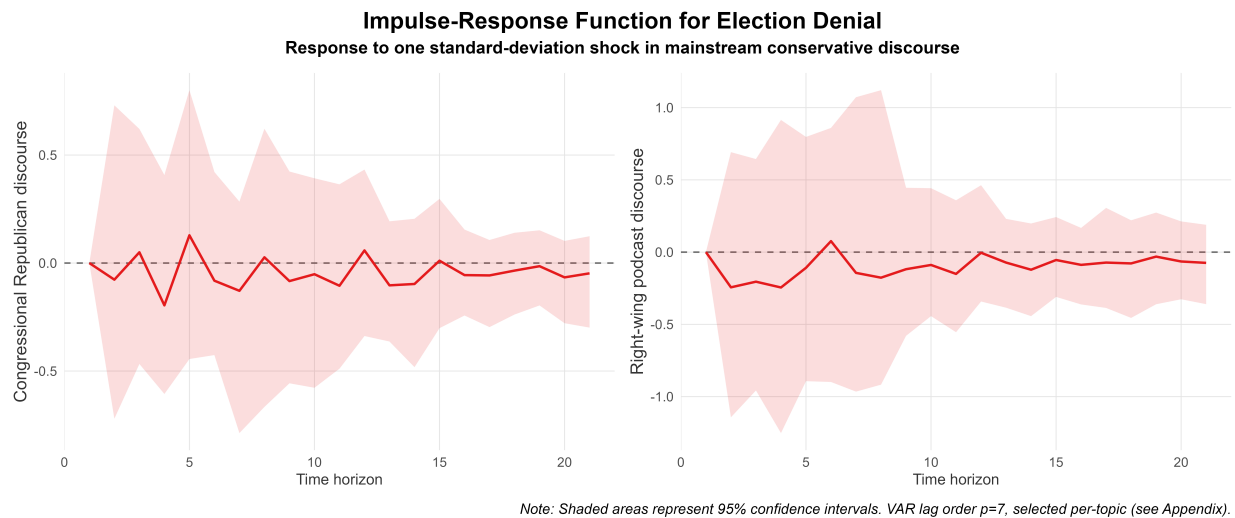


Figure 3: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to mainstream conservative discourse about election denial.

in the opposite direction; this is an empirical example of what we have characterized as mainstreaming, in this instance direct mainstreaming.

In contrast, some issue areas show little evidence of influence in any direction among any of the actors examined in our study. For one example of such a topic, where substantial amounts of discussion happen in all three of our text collections and where high-profile political maneuvers continue up to the time of writing, consider the domain of conspiracy theories regarding GMOs and global agribusiness. From globalist conspiracies to poison our food supply, through supplement sales, and up to the Make America Healthy Again agenda of the second Trump administration, GMO-related theories and conspiratorial discourse about the food supply have long been, and remain, staple narratives across the spectrum of American conservative politics (Butler 2021).

Nevertheless, while all of our various actors discuss these topics, there is little evidence in our data that these groups are paying attention to each other on the timing or content of what they say regarding GMOs and other food- related conspiracies. As Figure 4 shows, discussion of these topics on right-wing podcasts has no statistically significant effect on subsequent discourse among either Congressional Republicans or mainstream conservatives, at any of the 20 weekly horizons we examine. The impression the data give is unambiguously one of no effect rather than of a consistent directionality.

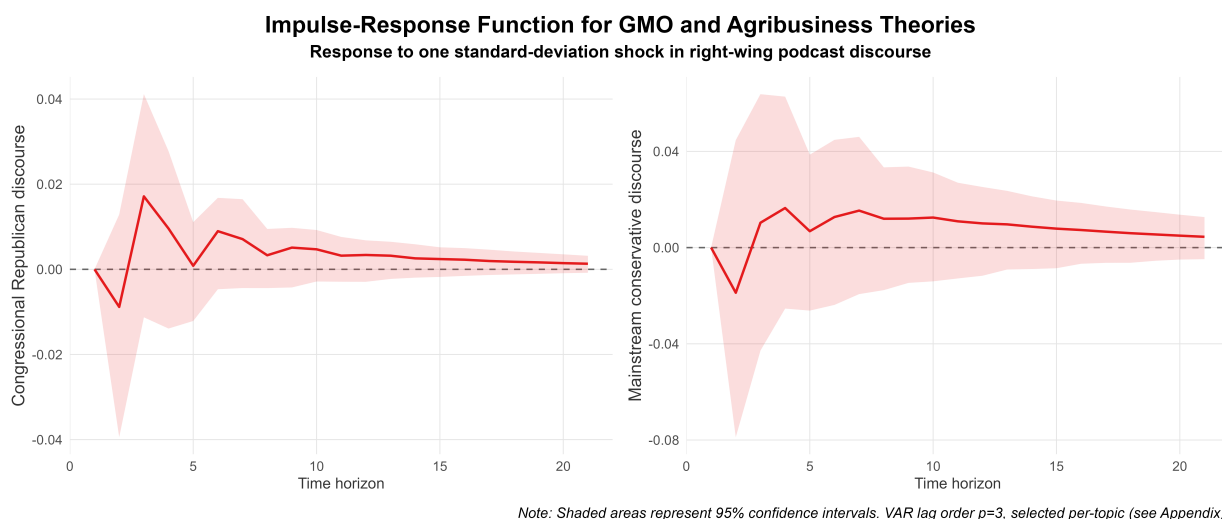


Figure 4: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to right-wing podcast discourse about GMO and agribusiness Theories.

The results for a shock to Congressional Republican discourse in Figure 5 are similar, with one narrow exception: right-wing podcast discourse shows a single, very short-lived positive response in the week immediately following a shock to Congressional discussion, but no other significant effect at any other horizon, and no significant effect on mainstream conservative discourse at all. This isolated, immediate-term result is not the kind of sustained, multi-week pattern we treat elsewhere as evidence of a genuine relationship of influence, and the overall impression remains one of very limited or no relationship.

The same can certainly be said for the pattern involving shocks to mainstream conservative discussion on this topic, shown in Figure 6. Here, nothing is significant, and the results as a whole require little interpretation. There is just not much going on.

Across these sets of findings, we have a scenario in which Congressional Republicans, mainstream conservatives, and right-wing voices all speak about GMOs and other food-related conspiracies. These topics take on new framings and details all the time, as supplements cycle through the market and trends in the alternative health community come and go. However, the core themes remain consistent and ubiquitous in this space: the need for purity, authenticity, virtue, trust, local ties, responsibility, personal authority over health decisions, tradition and hidden wisdom over science, etc. When each actor in our study pursues a

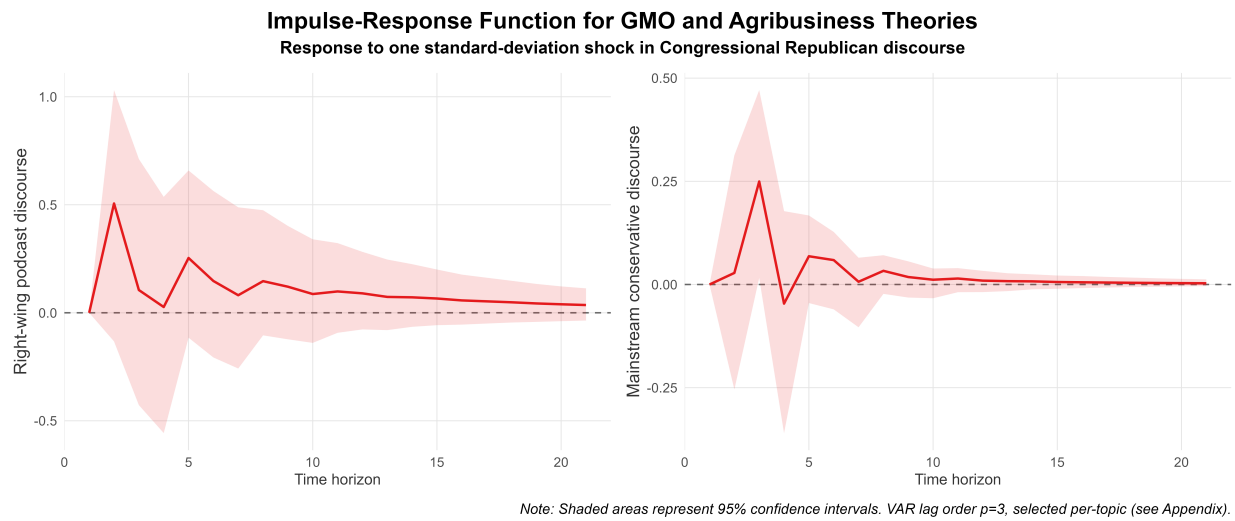


Figure 5: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to Congressional Republican discourse about GMO and agribusiness Theories.

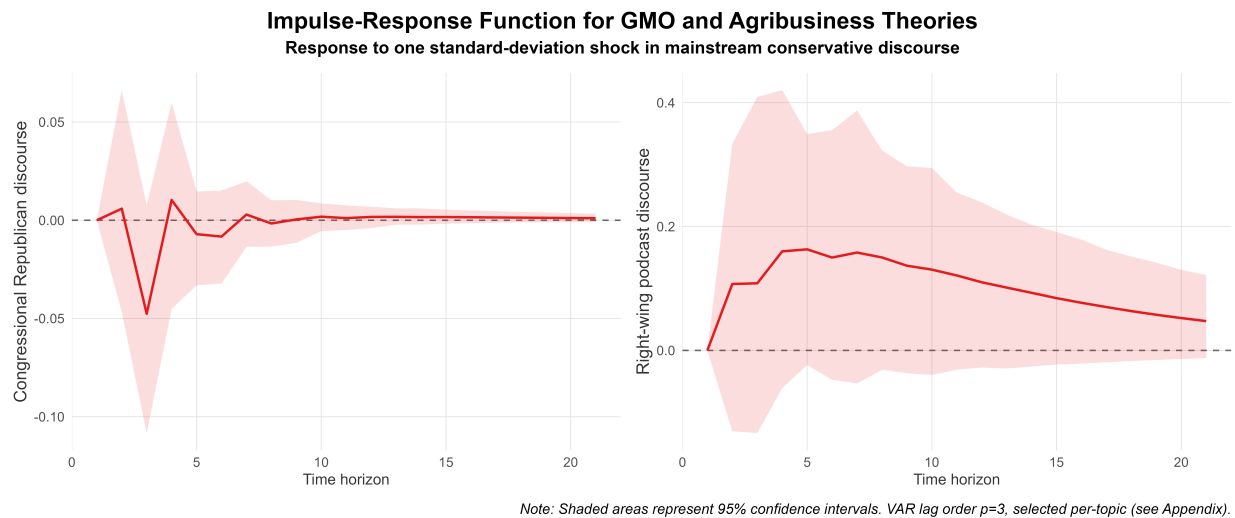


Figure 6: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to mainstream conservative discourse about GMO and agribusiness Theories.

topic without direct influence from the others, we refer to this as an example of a discourse dominated by *independent streams*.

This independent streams dynamic is what we expect to see in time periods and/or issue areas where right-wing mainstreaming is weak or incomplete. When professional conservative politicians see themselves as having distinct interests, audiences, and ideology in comparison with right-wing media voices on a particular issue, politicians are unlikely to either listen to the messaging of the right wing on this issue or speak about the issue in ways intended for right-wing consumption. Instead, politicians can be expected to pursue messaging that reflects their beliefs and their electorate, while the right wing does the same regarding their own, as yet separate sphere.

Finally, for some topic areas, influence flows from Congressional Republican discourse toward the right wing. Consider discourse organized around the demand that Antifa, the loosely affiliated network of anti-fascist activist groups, be formally designated a domestic terrorist organization. This is a case in which Republican elected officials, rather than right-wing media, initiated an idea that later circulated through more extreme venues. Senator Bill Cassidy, joined by Senator Ted Cruz, introduced S. Res. 279 in the Senate in July 2019, calling for groups operating under the Antifa banner to be designated domestic terrorist organizations, citing the assault of journalist Andy Ngo in Portland, Oregon and the doxxing and harassment of ICE employees. The following summer, Antifa-aligned protesters occupied the area around the Mark O. Hatfield federal courthouse in Portland for more than sixty days, an episode that, by the resolution’s own account, left over 250 federal officers injured; President Trump publicly vowed that his administration would move to designate Antifa a domestic terrorist organization in the aftermath. Roughly eight months later, Representative Lauren Boebert, joined by ten Republican cosponsors, introduced an essentially identical resolution, H. Res. 272, in the House in March 2021. On both occasions, it was Republican members of Congress, not far-right broadcasters, who originated the idea of “Antifa as a domestic terrorist organization,” raised it on the floor of Congress, and even repeatedly reintroduced it as formal legislative business.

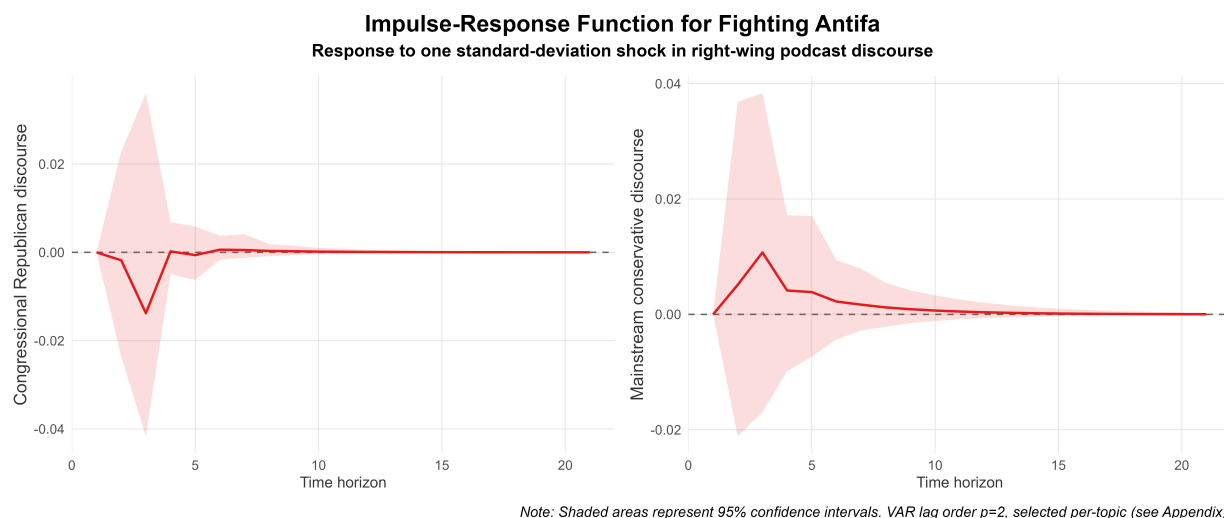


Figure 7: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to right-wing podcast discourse about Fighting Antifa.

As Figure 7 shows, a shock to right-wing podcast discourse about Antifa produces no statistically significant subsequent response in either Congressional Republican or mainstream conservative discourse, at any horizon we examine. This is not a topic area where mainstream conservatives are borrowing language, frames, or political momentum from the far right, in spite of the obvious political synergies involved here.

Congressional Republican discourse, by contrast, has real predictive power. As Figure 8 shows, a shock to Congressional Republican discourse produces a sharp, short-lived positive response in right-wing podcast discourse, peaking two to three weeks after the initial shock and decaying back to zero within roughly two months; there is no comparable response in mainstream conservative discourse.

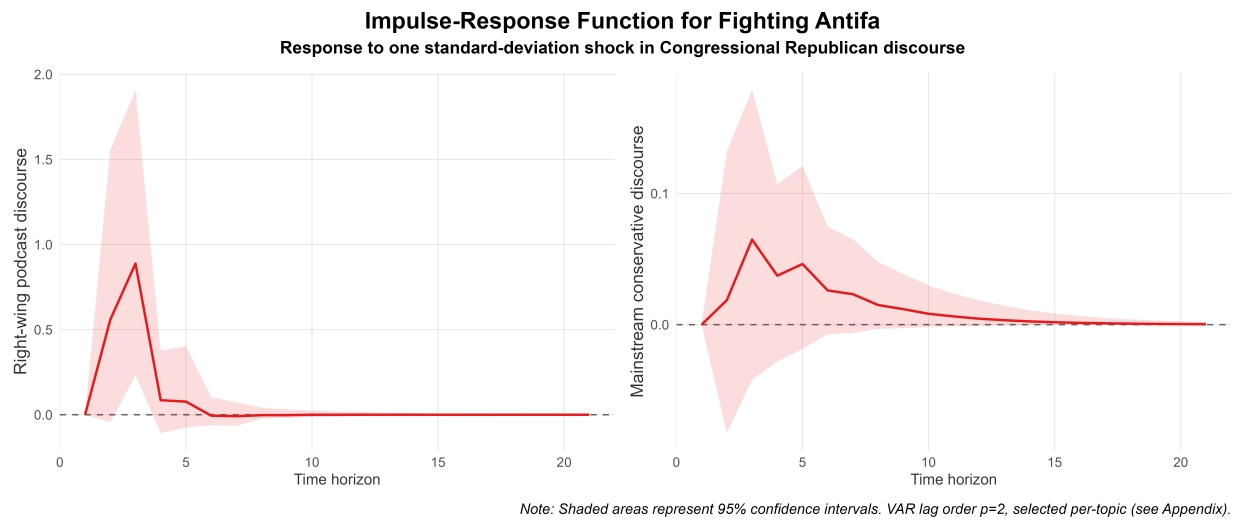


Figure 8: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to Congressional Republican discourse about Fighting Antifa.

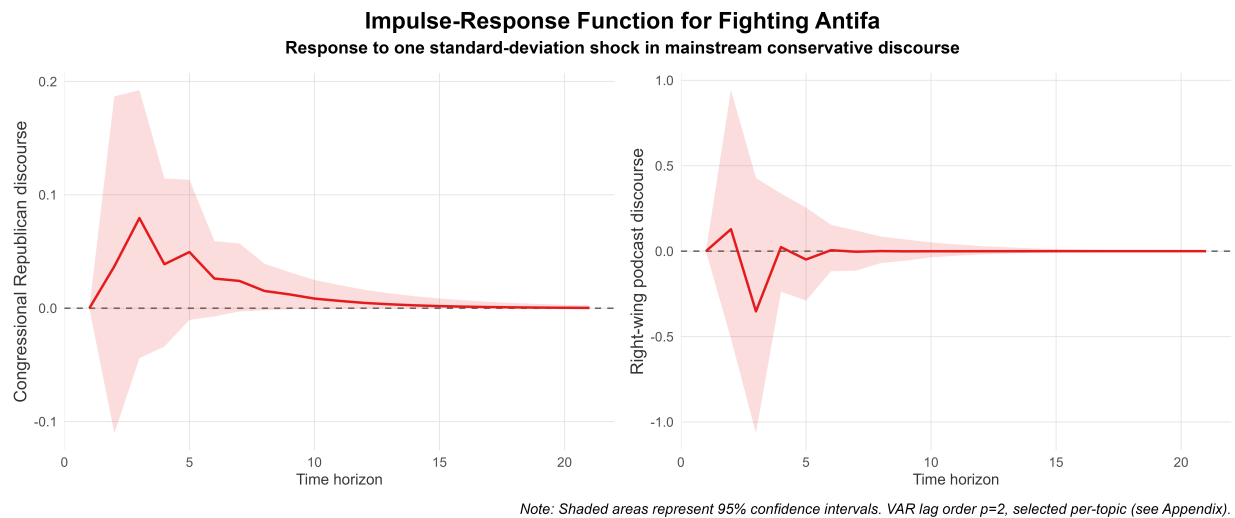


Figure 9: Impulse-response functions involving shocks to mainstream conservative discourse about Fighting Antifa.

Finally, as Figure 9 shows, mainstream conservative discourse about Antifa has no statistically significant effect on either of the other two actors. Given the degree of attention Congressional Republicans and other governmental actors raised on this issue, the lack of influence here is noteworthy.

Taken together, these results describe a clean case of amplification: right-wing podcasts pick up and echo Congressional Republican messaging about Antifa within a matter of weeks, but Congressional Republicans show no corresponding tendency to pick up far-right framing on this issue, and mainstream conservative media plays no meaningful role in the exchange. This reading fits the historical record. It was Republican members of Congress — Cassidy and Cruz in 2019, Boebert and her ten cosponsors in 2021, with Trump’s own public commitment to the designation in between — who initiated and repeatedly reintroduced the specific legislative framing of Antifa as a domestic terrorist organization, supplying right-wing media with a ready-made, politically legitimated frame to amplify rather than one right-wing media had to originate on its own.

Having introduced these categories of relationships, the major analytical question is how common each category is overall in the data. Our data include a time period from 2003 to 2024, a historical trajectory during which the American right wing moved from a substantially marginal position into a quite close relationship with mainstream electoral conservatives (Fording and Schram 2020). Thus, analyzing this period as a whole and considering the different character of the movements in question, we expect to find a mix of relationships.

It should be true that the predominant relationship involves independent streams; after all, for a substantial period of the analysis, the right wing was not mainstream. Furthermore, mainstream conservatives have a large pool of already-established ideological narratives. Hence, we expect to see significant numbers of topics — especially those that were dominant early in this historical window — where Congressional Republicans and right-wing media voices show little direct influence on each others’ speech patterns.

Starting with the Ron Paul presidential runs in 2008 and 2012, the Tea Party movement that went broad in 2009, and escalating with Donald Trump’s presidential campaign starting in 2015, right-wing voices in the U.S. made a sustained and ultimately successful effort to connect with and win influence within mainstream politics. We expect this period of time to have left a substantial mark on the data in the form of a meaningful number of topics where there should be relationships of amplification and direct or indirect mainstreaming.

Furthermore, we expect mainstreaming to be increasingly prevalent among politicians who came to power toward the end of this period and in issue areas where mainstream Republicans have less established ideological messaging. The simplest way to think of the domain of relative strength of the far right in terms of messaging is that it corresponds to the space scholars have studied under the rubric of the populist right (Mouffe 2005); it will include topics related to the oppression of the people by corrupt elites, the collusion of the state and some cultural leaders with immigrants to destroy the country, and relatively raw expressions of right-wing identity politics. On these kinds of topics, there is weak existing messaging on the part of mainstream Republicans, whether because it has been deliberately avoided by past generations of Republicans who cultivated close relationships with elites and sought a more moderate image. As a result, right-wing actors do not have to contest established mainstream stances in order to introduce their own perspectives. This is strategically helpful when they are trying to introduce themselves as viable political partners to the movement.

We expect amplification, in contrast, to focus particularly on the kind of movement-building policies and projects that are core to mainstream Republicans working to create something like the MAGA coalition. Right-wing actors can easily pick up attacks on enemy individuals, movements, or societal groups, and amplifying these attacks can energize a right-wing audience while creating resonance between the far right and mainstream conservatives. Likewise, on a more transactional level, right-wing actors can rebroadcast the sales schemes and fundraising projects that have been central to the MAGA identity, in exchange for whatever monetary, political, or personal payoff they might receive. In any of these actions, right-wing broadcasters have the chance to demonstrate their value to their potential mainstream partners while creating low-effort content for their own broadcasts. These kinds of topics are easy to amplify because they generally contain little complex ideological content, and as such they can reinforce partnership between mainstream electoral Republicans and the right wing without stressing either side’s priorities.

Finally, we anticipate that two-way dialogue will happen in contexts that reflect the intersection of the domains of mainstreaming and amplification: they will involve policy domains, events, and movement-building initiatives that are thin in terms of ideological relevance for established Republican stances but that have solid connections to right-populist thought. Examples in our time frame include the Ron Paul campaign (which involves substantial movement-building activity, as well as a wide range of right-populist messaging), conspiracy theories about COVID’s potential origin as a human-constructed bioweapon (which was used by Republicans as a movement-building tool to rally support for Trump and MAGA during 2020, but which also obviously resonates with ideas of corrupt and treacherous elites), Trump’s impeachments (which were critical mobilization and fundraising opportunities for Trump’s political machine, but which also fit powerfully into right-populist deep-state narratives), and various international conflicts that can both spotlight Trump’s leadership and open narratives about globalist machinations.

To analyze these expectations, we classify every topic in the data (129 in total) into one of five categories: amplification, direct mainstreaming, indirect mainstreaming, or two-way dialogue. To classify topics, we run a vector autoregression like those above, with a linear trend and a lag order selected separately for each topic as described above. We then look at the levels of significance in the impulse-response functions. If there are at least two significant effects at the 0.05 level connecting right-wing media voices to Congressional Republicans but not more than one significant effect flowing in the opposite direction, we classify that topic as characterized by direct mainstreaming. If there are at least two significant effects connecting right-wing media with mainstream conservative media, and also at least two effects connecting mainstream conservative media with Congressional Republicans, but not more than one in the opposite direction, we classify the topic as indirect mainstreaming.

If there is evidence of an equivalent effect (direct or indirect) in the opposite direction only, we classify the topic as amplification. For this analysis, we have not differentiated between direct and indirect amplification, although this may be of interest in future work. When there are two or more statistically significant effects flowing in both directions — from Republicans in Congress toward far-right media figures and also back — we classify the topic as marked by two-way dialogue. Finally, when the topic does not meet any of the criteria described so far, it falls into the category of independent streams.

Table 1: Overall Classification of Topics by Communication Relationship

Communication Relationship	Number of Topics
Amplification	11
Direct Mainstreaming	4
Indirect Mainstreaming	1
Independent Streams	107
Two-Way Dialogue	6

Table 1 presents the overall classification of topics according to these criteria (the Amplification row includes one topic classified as indirect amplification, consistent with our decision not to distinguish direct from indirect amplification). The predominant category is independent streams, at 107 of 129 topics, or about 83% of the topic list as a whole.² Direct mainstreaming is present in a select collection of topics: 4, or about 3% of the topic list. Indirect mainstreaming occurs once, about 1% of the list. In combination, some form of mainstreaming appears in roughly 4% of topics. Amplification occurs somewhat more often, in 11 topics, or about 9% of the list. Two-way dialogue is rarer still, occurring in 6 topics, or about 5% of the list.

Read at face value, these figures might seem to suggest that cross-actor influence of any kind is a marginal phenomenon: on 83% of topics we find no statistical evidence of any connection between right-wing podcasts, Congressional Republicans, and mainstream conservative media. We do not think this is the right way to read the results, and we want to be explicit that we are not claiming the far right is a numerically predominant source of Republican discourse on the floor of Congress. Rather, as the topic-by-topic breakdown below shows, influence is channeled into specific substantive areas rather than spread evenly across the full range

²Topics are of course not equally weighted in the various text collections, so this percentage metric should be treated as a rough guide.

of Congressional speech. On topics unconnected to right-populist ideology or to the tactical project of building the MAGA coalition, Congressional Republicans draw on other sources entirely, and no evidence of far-right influence appears. But on the comparatively narrow set of topics that touch core right-populist commitments, or that serve as tactical vehicles for coalition-building, the far right is a demonstrable reference point, exactly where our theoretical account would predict it to matter most.

Alongside the overall percentages, our theoretical expectations regarding the historical trajectory of mainstreaming can also be productively tested by examining the actual topics that fall within each category. In listing topics, we will provide names that the researchers assigned to each topic based on in-depth reading of multiple high-scoring examples of each prior to carrying out the time-series analysis.

Table 2: Topics Involved in Mainstreaming

Topic	Estimated Relationship
Christian Persecution	Direct Mainstreaming
Election Fraud and Election Denial	Direct Mainstreaming
Anti-Establishment, Anti-Globalist, Anti-Satanist	Direct Mainstreaming
People versus Evil Elite	Direct Mainstreaming
Black Lives Matter, Race, and Law Enforcement	Indirect Mainstreaming

Table 2 lists the topics classified as involving direct or indirect mainstreaming. A less conservative specification (reported in the Appendix) had identified a wider and more heterogeneous mix of novel events and taboo subjects; the topics that survive this more conservative specification instead cluster tightly around the substantive core of right-populist ideology itself. Christian persecution narratives and election fraud are foundational grievances of the contemporary right-populist and MAGA-aligned worldview; an explicitly anti-globalist, anti-establishment, anti-Satanist conspiracy frame and a generalized narrative of struggle against a corrupt “evil elite” are close to that worldview’s ideological center; and one topic, involving racialized narratives about Black Lives Matter and policing, reaches Congress indirectly, having first passed through mainstream conservative media. These are not incidental or event-driven topics. This supports a version of our original hypothesis that is narrower, but we think more precise: mainstreaming is not diffuse borrowing across arbitrary novel subjects, but the adoption by Congressional Republicans of the far right’s own foundational interpretive frames.

Table 3: Topics Involved in Amplification

Topic	Estimated Relationship
Joe Biden and Kamala Harris	Amplification
Covid Quarantines	Amplification
Ferguson Protests	Amplification
Qanon Ideas	Amplification
Pride Flags and Institutional Support	Amplification
Fighting Antifa	Amplification
Steaks	Amplification
Globalists and Muslims	Amplification
Suits and Men’s Fashion	Amplification
Trump Scandals	Amplification
Homophobia	Indirect Amplification

Table 3 shows the topics where an amplification relationship exists. Where a less conservative specification (reported in the Appendix) had identified a broader and more heterogeneous mix of scandals and news events, the topics that survive here read less like opportunistic reactions to whatever is in the news cycle and more like tactical vehicles for building and signaling loyalty to the MAGA coalition specifically. Partisan-conflict topics tied to Trump and his immediate political rivals (Joe Biden and Kamala Harris, Trump Scandals) sit alongside

culture-war mobilization themes central to right-populist messaging (QAnon, Fighting Antifa, Pride Flags and Institutional Support, Ferguson Protests, COVID quarantine restrictions) and a conspiratorial framing of an international threat (Globalists and Muslims, and, indirectly, Homophobia).

Two of the remaining topics, “Steaks” and “Suits and Men’s Fashion,” might strike readers as anomalous, but both involve entrepreneurial, sales-oriented content connected to Trump and other right-aligned commercial ventures. We read right-wing media’s amplification of this commercial messaging as a low-cost signal of loyalty to Trump-aligned entrepreneurial projects, of a piece with the amplification the far right offers Congressional Republicans more generally, rather than as substantive political amplification in its own right.

Table 4: Topics Involved in Two-Way Dialogue

Topic	Estimated Relationship
Ron Paul Big Government Conspiracies	Two-Way Dialogue
Russian Discourse about Ukraine	Two-Way Dialogue
Covid as a Bioweapon, Lockdown, Etc.	Two-Way Dialogue
Israel, Palestine, and Antisemitism	Two-Way Dialogue
Impeachment	Two-Way Dialogue
North Korea	Two-Way Dialogue

Two-way dialogue, in which far-right media and Congressional Republicans both draw on and respond to one another, is the rarest of the non-independent categories, appearing in only six topics, listed in Table 4. These are overwhelmingly policy and international-relations topics on which right-populist conspiratorial framing — suspicion of globalist institutions, foreign adversaries, and a corrupt or compromised elite — intersects with subjects that are also live matters of mainstream partisan and foreign-policy debate: Russia and Ukraine, North Korea, Israel/Palestine and antisemitism, an international disease-origin conspiracy (COVID as a bioweapon), a domestic institutional conflict (impeachment), and Ron Paul’s libertarian-inflected suspicion of federal power. Two-way dialogue appears specifically where an international or major domestic conflict is itself readily assimilable to a pre-existing right-populist conspiratorial frame, so that both sides have independent reason to keep returning to the same theme. As the full impulse-response results in the Appendix show, at least one of these cases (COVID as a bioweapon) is better described as a conversation centered on right-wing podcasts and mainstream conservative media, with Congressional Republicans a real but comparatively modest participant in both directions — a reminder that a single categorical label can obscure meaningful differences in the relative strength of the pairwise relationships that underlie it.

A final test of our expectations can be performed by dividing the Republican members of Congress into groups based on whether they entered before or after the period in time when we hypothesize that the mainstreaming process consolidated. It seems both convenient and plausible to date that consolidation with Trump’s presidential election in 2016; thus, we can split the Congressional sample into those member of Congress who were elected before Trump and those who were elected in 2016 or later. For the before-Trump sample, the analysis will include the full range of dates described above, although members will start to fall out of the data set over time. For the post-Trump sample, by definition, the data do not exist until the year 2017 and therefore cannot include earlier periods.

Having split the data in these ways, we analyze them in the same framework as before. Our original expectation was that the mainstreaming process would show a clear generational structure: more instances of mainstreaming, and less two-way dialogue, among the pre-Trump cohort, whose relationship to far-right media was still being negotiated, and the reverse pattern among the post-Trump cohort, who entered a communication environment in which that relationship was already established. As we show below, the data only partly bear this out, and in a more interesting way than we anticipated.

Table 5 shows the classification of topics for Republican members of Congress elected before Donald Trump’s 2016 presidential victory (covering all years in our data, up to 2024; the Amplification row includes three indirect-amplification cases). Some form of mainstreaming appears in 4 of 129 topics (3%), amplification in 8 (6%), and two-way dialogue in 8 (6%) — broadly similar in scale to the pooled results.

Table 5: Pre-Trump Classification of Topics by Communication Relationship

Communication Relationship	Number of Topics
Amplification	8
Direct Mainstreaming	3
Indirect Mainstreaming	1
Independent Streams	109
Two-Way Dialogue	8

Table 6: Post-Trump Classification of Topics by Communication Relationship

Communication Relationship	Number of Topics
Amplification	3
Direct Mainstreaming	6
Indirect Mainstreaming	1
Independent Streams	112
Two-Way Dialogue	7

The post-Trump cohort in Table 6 does differ from the pre-Trump cohort, but not in the way we originally expected. Two-way dialogue is essentially unchanged across cohorts: 8 topics pre-Trump versus 7 post-Trump, out of 129 in each case. Thus, there is no evidence that Republicans elected after Trump’s 2016 victory are more likely than their pre-Trump colleagues to engage far-right media in a mutual, reciprocal exchange of frames.

What does change is the composition of the one-directional relationships. Direct mainstreaming roughly doubles, from 3 pre-Trump topics to 6 post-Trump topics, while amplification (including indirect cases) falls by more than half, from 8 pre-Trump topics to 3 post-Trump topics. We read this as a different, and in some ways more interesting, story than the one we originally hypothesized. Rather than the relationship between the far right and Congressional Republicans becoming more mutual or egalitarian over time, post-Trump Republicans appear more likely than their pre-Trump colleagues to draw on far-right media as a trusted resource for interpreting the world — adopting far-right frames and language as legitimate ways of talking about a topic — and correspondingly less likely to use far-right channels merely as an instrumental platform for extending the tactical reach of their own messaging. The specific topics involved in each category for both cohorts (reported in full in the Appendix) fit this overall pattern: mainstreaming topics for the post-Trump cohort cluster around the same core right-populist themes identified in the pooled analysis, while amplification in both cohorts remains tied to tactical, partisan-conflict, and coalition-signaling content.

In summary, our data show a pattern of communication relationships between far-right actors and Congressional Republicans that is narrower, and more concentrated, than the aggregate numbers alone might suggest. The great majority of topics show no statistical evidence of cross-actor influence, but the topics that do are not scattered at random: mainstreaming clusters tightly around the substantive core of right-populist ideology; amplification clusters around the tactical, coalition-building work of constructing and signaling loyalty to the MAGA project; and two-way dialogue, rarest of all, appears specifically where international or major domestic conflicts are already assimilable to a right-populist conspiratorial frame. The comparison across pre- and post-Trump cohorts adds a further layer: rather than becoming more mutual over time, the relationship instead shifts in kind, from an instrumental, tactical use of far-right channels toward a more substantive reliance on far-right media as a source of interpretive authority.

These results fit well with a model of strategic, and evolving, communication and relationship-building over time from the perspective of far-right actors. We will discuss implications for literatures on far-right mainstreaming and normalization, party politics, and democratic backsliding in the next section.

Discussion

We have demonstrated that rhetorical linkages between far-right media and Republican elites are structured, not random: the great majority of topics display independent streams, but a focused and substantively coherent set of topics exhibit amplification from congressional speech into media, direct or indirect mainstreaming from far-right media into Congress, or two-way dialogue between the two. Taken together, these dynamics suggest that diffusion hinges not simply on a “fringe-to-mainstream pipeline” but on the micro-institutions that translate, sanitize, and route messages through the contemporary right-wing information ecosystem, and that those micro-institutions are activated selectively, on topics tied to the substantive core of right-populist ideology or to the tactical work of coalition-building, rather than uniformly across the full range of Congressional speech.

A natural locus for these micro-institutions is congressional staff. Prior work identifies three features that are directly relevant to our patterns. First, senior staff often misread constituency opinion and overweight signals from organized interests, which can bias the selection and framing of content that reaches members (Hertel-Fernandez, Mildener and Stokes, 2019). Second, comparative evidence describes political staff as high-intensity party activists rather than neutral bureaucrats, suggesting that staff bring programmatic commitments into the office (Moens, 2022). Third, staff networks have measurable effects on members’ roll calls and legislative effectiveness, which implies that staff carry frames and heuristics across offices and can shape the behavior of the principals they serve (Montgomery and Nyhan, 2017).

Taken together, these findings point toward a staff-centered hypothesis regarding the dynamics we document. Direct mainstreaming is consistent with staff who monitor ideologically proximate media, translate emergent frames into floor and committee speech, and prioritize them when party scripts are thin on core right-populist topics. Amplification is consistent with staff routines that package member remarks for allied outlets and influencers on tactical, coalition-building topics, producing observable House-to-media responses in the short run. The comparatively rare instances of genuine two-way dialogue we observe are concentrated in international and major domestic policy conflicts where right-populist conspiratorial framing already coincides with mainstream partisan debate, consistent with offices in which the same staff both monitor and feed back into that shared media ecosystem specifically on those topics.

This interpretation also aligns with the cohort split, though not in the way we initially expected. Two-way dialogue — the pattern that would most directly indicate staff networks routinely both ingesting and distributing content across the aisle between Congress and far-right media — does not become more common among post-2016 offices; if anything it is marginally less common than among pre-2016 offices. What increases substantially among post-2016 offices is direct mainstreaming, while amplification falls by more than half. This is more consistent with a narrower staff-centered mechanism: post-2016 offices, staffed and hired within an information environment in which far-right media was already an established presence, may be more disposed to treat far-right framing as a legitimate interpretive resource on core right-populist topics, while relying less on far-right channels as a tactical amplification vehicle for the party’s own messaging. Our design does not identify staff effects directly, but the staff literature indicates a mechanism that is coherent with this more specific pattern in our VAR and IRF results. The role of staff in structuring these diffusion dynamics remains an important area for further research.

The patterns we document are consistent with a new media landscape where production costs are low, editorial gatekeeping is weak, and distribution is rapid. In that setting, podcasts and similar formats can originate highly specific or norm-violating frames that travel quickly into elite discourse when party scripts are thin, matching our direct mainstreaming cases. The short-run House → media effects on scandal and partisan conflict topics align with routinized repackaging of member remarks by allied outlets, which we classify as amplification. The shift among post-2016 members — toward more mainstreaming and less amplification, with no change in the rate of genuine two-way dialogue — fits a context in which alternative outlets have become an established interpretive authority on a narrow set of ideologically central topics, even as most Congressional discourse continues to draw on other sources entirely.

A further implication is strategic use of the far right by party elites of various kinds, potentially involving contexts of social-movement mobilization and coalition-building beyond the textual data used in the body of this analysis. The amplification patterns we document permit an interpretation in which institutional actors

leverage right-wing activists as a force multiplier while preserving some degree of arm's length deniability. Outsourcing transgressive rhetoric and action to ideologically proximate outlets can test frames, impose agenda costs on opponents, and energize core supporters, after which selected messages and agendas re-enter the conservative mainstream once their utility is apparent.

January 6 illustrates the hazards and logic of this strategy. During the interval between the election and January 6th, the movement contesting the election pursued two fundamentally different and separate tracks. First, there was an institutional track, involving legal actions, attempts to generate alternative slates of electors and alternative counts in states such as Georgia, and ultimately efforts to overturn the election in Congress (Warf 2023a). This track included direct participation by a wide range of individuals with close ties to Donald Trump, as well as some direct participation by Trump himself.

Second, there was a public demonstration track, involving rallies, petitions, and protest actions. This track was led by figures such as Amy Kremer, a Tea Party organizer who reached a mass following with her Women for America First Facebook group (Hoffman, Leslie, and Ifeanyichukwu 2025); Ali Alexander, a far-right influencer who had built a platform on Periscope and Twitter and who organized a tour of Stop the Steal events (Salek 2023); and the Proud Boys, an internet-centric gang organized by online celebrity and podcaster Gavin McInness that participated heavily in the protest activity (Kenes 2021). While there is certainly no reason to believe that Trump did not support this more public track, and in fact his social media activity suggests that he did, there was substantially less direct involvement by him and his close allies than in the institutional track.

As the final vote sealing the 2020 presidential election approached on January 6th, 2021, Trump and his close allies realized that their institutional effort risked falling short, with the number of members of Congress committed to their effort below the necessary threshold and with the vice president rebuffing their persuasive calls (Warf 2023b). So Trump's proxy, Roger Stone, connected with members of the alt-right and others organizing public demonstrations in order to help coordinate an effort to increase pressure on Congress through demonstrations at the White House and on Capitol Hill (US House Select Committee 2022: 517-19). During the event, messaging pivoted over time from institutional themes about vote counting that dominated during Trump's official rally near the White House toward far-right themes about the Q-Anon conspiracy, globalists, and the Deep State that were predominant during the event at Capitol Hill.

On the day of January 6th, these far-right demonstrators were not successful in their attempt to persuade members of Congress. The election vote was ultimately carried out as planned, and Trump did not persuade enough people to support him to disrupt the transition to the Biden administration. However, over a longer window of time, far-right persuasion around January 6th did succeed in some degree of persuasion vis-a-vis Republicans in Congress. By July 1, 2021, when the House of Representatives formed the January 6th Select Committee, only two Republicans were willing to serve, with others regarding the idea of investigating the event as a partisan maneuver. On February 4, 2022, the Republican National Committee officially censured both of the Republicans who did serve on that committee. Early in Donald Trump's second term as president, he pardoned all individuals convicted of crimes related to January 6th; Republican Senators blocked an attempted vote, sponsored by all Democrats in the chamber, condemning those pardons.

Conclusions

The movement of far-right actors, organizations, and parties from the political periphery and toward the levers of power has been one of the central historical events of recent times across a wide range of countries. Whether this trajectory involves the creation of new parties, the capture of power by personalist leaders, or a transformation of existing parties and institutions from within, these changes have justly received a great deal of attention.

The textual time-series data examined here allows a more fine-grained picture of how and when some of the political relationships and alliances were constructed that facilitated these changes in the United States. The data show a long-term effort by voices on the far right to reach toward the mainstream by supplying interpretive frames on the substantive core of right-populist ideology, for which mainstream conservatives lacked existing political language, and by offering tactical amplification of Republican messaging in service of building the MAGA coalition. Rather than culminating in a new status quo of pervasive, general-purpose

two-way dialogue, the data instead show conservatives elected during the Trump era relying more heavily on far-right media specifically as a source of interpretive authority on core ideological topics, and correspondingly less on far-right channels as an instrumental, tactical amplification vehicle — a narrower, but we think clearer, portrait of how the far right achieved political access. These data help identify key and often overlooked or minimized actors on both ends of the process.

More generally, this analysis provides a framework for thinking about far-right mainstreaming and normalization as processes of elite relationship-building and communication over time. Both the statistical tools used in this discussion and the conceptual framework of analyzing persuasion and communication relationships in terms of acts of mainstreaming, amplification, and two-way dialogue may have broader application — either to a wider set of far-right actors in the U.S. and elsewhere or to other political contexts. At a theoretical level, we invite readers to imagine large-scale elite transformations as series of events involving interactions among people with motives, strategies, and needs. As in this analysis, such a perspective can offer insights often otherwise missed.

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